of the hall. At first, I was doing my best to keep a smile on my face, frozen as it was. I took a deep breath and glanced down to my left where Victoria was sitting with the senior Real Madrid staff in a cordoned off area. She was looking back up at me, as if to say:

‘Go on, then. This is it, you know. We’re all watching you.’

I really was smiling now. Behind me was a cinema screen, huge enough to make me feel about a foot tall down here on the stage. Just for an instant, it felt like Saturday morning at the movies, except the film had me in it. Against a burnt yellow background: my head, the club badge, the words Real Madrid. Senor Perez stepped forward. They were going to translate me into Spanish. But there was no one translating him into English for me. They’d never have kept up anyway. It was only later that I got the President’s drift.

‘David is a great player, a player who’s been educated in the tradition of sacrificing himself to the team. He comes to the best and most competitive league in the world. We are sure he is technically good enough and a strong enough character to succeed.’

Now, Alfredo di Stefano stepped forward with a Madrid team shirt in his hands. We shook hands, photographers calling out:

‘Over here, David. Aqui, aqui—por favor—Senors.’

We held the shirt out in front of us.

‘Turn it round, turn it round.’

On the back: 23 with ‘Beckham’ over the numerals. Nobody knew, outside the club, what my squad number was going to be. I’d thought long and hard about which number to choose from the ones that weren’t already being worn by the other players. Even Real hadn’t found out until late the previous night, when I’d phoned them from the hotel with my final decision.

There was a sudden burst of shutters clicking on a couple of hundred cameras. I could hear voices out in the hall:

‘Veinte y tres.’

Twenty-three. Then, a moment later:

‘Michael Jordan. Michael Jordan.’